

IP10

Governance: Public Policy, Citizen Charter, Social Audit, Grievance Redressal, RTI

About 2-3 questions a paper across Indian and Rajasthan Polity. Documented repeats: the Citizen's Charter 'which element is NOT a component' question (2021 and 2024), the RTI commencement date (2018), the 48-hour life-and-liberty limit (2021), the Rs 25,000 maximum penalty (2023) and the CIC appointment committee (2023). Five near-certain marks sitting in a chapter people leave unread.

This is the half of the syllabus most candidates skip, and RPSC keeps asking it. It is not theory-heavy. It is a set of named principles, named components, section numbers and time limits - all of which can be learnt in one sitting, and none of which can be guessed in the hall.

Governance, Transparency and RTI

Public policy

- Thomas Dye - 'to do or not to do'
- Harold Lasswell - father of the policy sciences
- Five stages: agenda to evaluation
- Simon, Lindblom, Etzioni, Easton

Citizen's Charter

- UK 1991, John Major
- Six principles - Quality, Choice, Standards, Value, Accountability, Transparency
- Six components - penalty is NOT one
- India: 24 May 1997, DARPG nodal
- Sevottam, IS 15700:2005

Social audit

- MGNREGA Section 17, 2005
- Gram Sabha, once every six months
- Audit of Scheme Rules 2011, with the CAG
- Meghalaya Act 2017 - first state
- MKSS 1990 Devdungri; Jan Sunwai

Grievance redressal

- CPGRAMS - run by DARPG
- 21 days since August 2024
- Appeal within 30 days
- Directorate of Public Grievances - Cabinet Secretariat
- Rajasthan Sampark portal

RTI Act 2005

- Sec 4 suo motu, Sec 6 request
- Sec 7 - 30 days / 48 hours
- Sec 8 exemptions, Sec 19 appeals
- Sec 20 - Rs 250 a day, max Rs 25,000
- CIC Sec 12, SIC Sec 15
- 2019 Amendment - tenure and salary

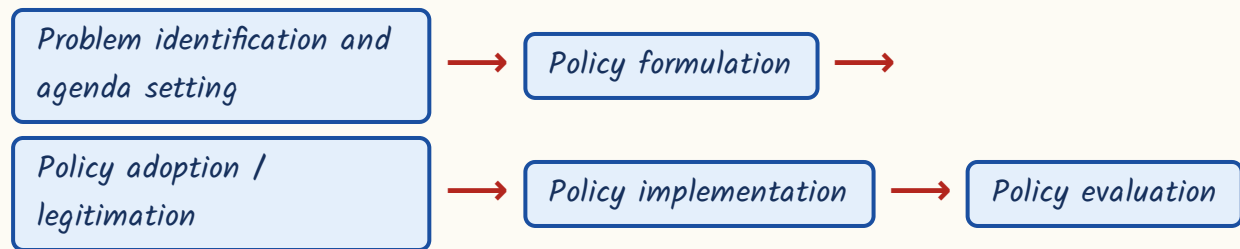
Good governance and e-governance

- 1st ARC 1966, 2nd ARC 2005
- SMART; the UN's eight attributes
- NeGP 2006, e-Kranti 2015
- Digital India 1 July 2015
- DBT 2013, UMANG 2017, Aadhaar Act 2016

Public policy - what it is, how it is made, who theorised it

Public policy is what the government decides to do about a public problem - and equally, what it decides NOT to do. That second half is the exam point. Thomas R. Dye's definition is the one RPSC quotes: public policy is 'whatever governments choose to do or not to do'. Harold Lasswell is regarded as the father of the policy sciences. A policy is never one act; it moves through named stages, and each stage has a job.

The five stages of the policy process



- Agenda setting is the stage at which a problem is recognised as needing government action.
- Formulation is where alternatives are designed; adoption is where the legislature or Cabinet legitimises the chosen one.
- Implementation is an EXECUTIVE and administrative function - the legislature legitimises and oversees, it does not implement.
- Evaluation asks whether the policy achieved its stated objectives, and feeds back into the next round of agenda setting.
- Evaluation may be formative, done during implementation, or summative, done after completion.

Model to thinker - a straight matching question

Model	Thinker	The idea in one line
Rational-comprehensive	-	Weigh every alternative and pick the optimum; assumes complete information
Bounded rationality	Herbert Simon	Human rationality is limited; the decision-maker satisfices instead of optimising
Incrementalism - 'the science of muddling through'	Charles E. Lindblom	Policy moves in small steps away from what already exists
Mixed scanning	Amitai Etzioni	A broad scan for big decisions, a detailed look for small ones - the middle path
Garbage-can model	Cohen, March and Olsen	Problems, solutions and participants collide almost randomly in organised anarchy

Model	Thinker	The idea in one line
Systems model	David Easton	Inputs, conversion, outputs and feedback within the political system

TRAP

Two standard false statements. One: 'policy implementation is carried out mainly by the legislature' - no, it is executive work. Two: swapping Simon and Lindblom. Keep the tags in order - Simon bounded, Lindblom muddling, Etzioni mixed, Easton systems.

Citizen's Charter - the six principles and the six components

A Citizen's Charter is a public declaration by a government office of the standard of service a citizen can expect from it, and what to do if that standard is not met. It is a promise, not a law. The idea started in the United Kingdom in 1991 under Prime Minister John Major. India adopted it after the Conference of Chief Ministers on 24 May 1997, which approved the 'Action Plan for Effective and Responsive Government'; the first charters were issued in 1997 and DARPG - the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances - is the nodal agency.

- The six PRINCIPLES, from the UK charter of 1991 - Quality: improving the quality of services
- Choice: wherever possible, choice for the user
- Standards: specify what to expect, and how to act if standards are not met
- Value: value for the taxpayer's money
- Accountability: of the individual and of the organisation
- Transparency: in rules, procedures, schemes and grievance redressal

- The six **COMPONENTS**, the actual contents of an Indian charter - Vision and mission statement of the organisation
- Details of the business transacted by the organisation
- Details of the clients - who the organisation serves
- Details of the services provided to each client group
- Details of the grievance redress mechanism and how to access it
- Expectations of the organisation from its clients

Do not let the two lists blur - principles vs components

Six PRINCIPLES (UK, 1991)	Six COMPONENTS (contents of a charter)
Quality	Vision and mission statement
Choice	Details of business transacted
Standards	Details of clients
Value	Details of services to each client group
Accountability	Grievance redress mechanism and how to access it
Transparency	Expectations from the clients

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 and again in RAS Pre 2024 - which one of the following is **NOT** a component of a Citizen's Charter? Answer: provision of penalty and punishment for officials who fail to meet the declared standards. A charter carries no penal provision at all. This is the most repeated question in the entire governance syllabus - do not lose it.

TRAP

Anything that sounds like enforcement is NOT a component - penalty, punishment, disciplinary action, compensation as of right, a right to sue. A Citizen's Charter is voluntary and non-justiciable; a citizen cannot sue on it. Its stated 'expectations' run from the organisation to the client, never as a penalty against the official. The standard criticism, also asked as a statement, is that charters are drafted without consulting the citizens they serve or the staff who must deliver them - which is why the 2nd ARC asked for measurable standards and a real grievance mechanism inside every charter.

Sevottam and the Right to Services Acts - making the promise

bite

Because the Citizen's Charter has no teeth, two things followed. First, DARPG built an assessment framework called Sevottam - from seva and uttam, excellence in service. Second, states began passing laws that actually guarantee delivery within a fixed time, with a penalty attached. Sevottam is the model; the Right to Services Acts are the enforcement.

- Sevottam has three modules: (1) Citizen's Charter, (2) Public Grievance Redress, (3) Service Delivery Capability.
- It is assessed against IS 15700:2005, an Indian Standard of the Bureau of Indian Standards.
- Remember DARPG for all three - the Citizen's Charter, Sevottam and CPGRAMS.
- Madhya Pradesh was the first state with a right-to-services law - the Public Service Guarantee Act, 2010, effective 25 September 2010.

- Bihar followed in 2011.
- Rajasthan enacted the Rajasthan Guaranteed Delivery of Public Services Act, 2011.
- Rajasthan also enacted the Rajasthan Right to Hearing Act, 2012 - the first such law in India.
- These Acts do what a charter cannot: fix a time limit, name a designated officer, allow an appeal and impose a penalty for default.

YAAD RAKHO

Two Rajasthan firsts, learn them as a pair and keep them apart. Right to Hearing Act 2012 - first in India. Guaranteed Delivery of Public Services Act 2011 - NOT the first; that honour is Madhya Pradesh's, 2010. RPSC swaps these two.

Social audit - and the Rajasthan movement behind it

A social audit is an audit done by the people the scheme is meant for. Records are read out in public, in the village, in front of everyone, and the beneficiaries themselves verify whether the muster roll, the measurement and the payment are true. It is not an accountant's audit. It is a public verification, and its legal home in India is one section of one Act.

- Social audit got its first statutory mandate in India through SECTION 17 of the MGNREGA, 2005.
- Section 17 requires the GRAM SABHA to conduct social audits of all works executed in the Gram Panchayat.
- The audit must be conducted at least once in every six months.
- The MGNREGA Audit of Scheme Rules, 2011 were framed in consultation with the Comptroller and Auditor General.

- Social audit SUPPLEMENTS the statutory financial audit by the CAG - it does not replace it.
- Meghalaya was the first state with a dedicated social audit law - the Meghalaya Community Participation and Public Services Social Audit Act, 2017.

The Jan Sunwai, or public hearing, tradition grew out of the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan, founded in 1990 at Devdungri in Rajsamand district by Aruna Roy, Nikhil Dey and Shankar Singh. Its slogan was 'Hamara Paisa, Hamara Hisab' - our money, our accounts. Workers demanded to see muster rolls and bills, read them aloud in the village, and asked those present to confirm or deny them. That local demand became the national campaign for the right to information, and eventually the RTI Act, 2005. This is a Rajasthan fact inside a national chapter, so it can appear in either paper.

TRAP

'Social audit was first mandated in India by the RTI Act, 2005' - wrong. It was Section 17 of MGNREGA, 2005. Both are 2005 Acts, which is precisely why RPSC uses this as the incorrectly matched pair.

ASKED IN RAS

The not-correctly-matched version of this question puts social audit against the RTI Act as the wrong pair. The three correct pairs beside it are worth learning in their own right - CPGRAMS with online grievance redress, Citizen's Charter with the United Kingdom 1991, and Sevottam with DARPG.

Grievance redressal - CPGRAMS and the machinery around it

CPGRAMS is the Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System - the single online portal on which a citizen lodges a complaint against any central ministry or department. It is run by DARPG, which sits in the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions. Learn its two numbers and its two nodal agencies; that is the whole question.

- *The redressal timeline was cut from 30 days to 21 DAYS in August 2024.*
- *An appeal against the disposal of a grievance lies to the designated Appellate Authority within 30 days.*
- *Every ministry and department has a designated Public Grievance Officer.*
- *Two nodal agencies at the central level: DARPG in the Ministry of Personnel, and the Directorate of Public Grievances, which functions under the CABINET SECRETARIAT.*
- *Rajasthan runs its own state grievance portal, Rajasthan Sampark, alongside CPGRAMS.*

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the 21-day CPGRAMS deadline fixed in August 2024 is the figure in force - if an option still says 30 days for disposal, it is the old rule. DARPG's monthly CPGRAMS reports and its ranking of ministries by disposal rate are standard current-affairs material.

RTI Act, 2005 - the sections, in order

The RTI Act is the most heavily examined single statute in this chapter. It replaced the toothless Freedom of Information Act, 2002. It received assent on 15 June 2005 and came fully into force on 12 October 2005 - learn both dates, because they appear as options together. It extends to the whole of India; Jammu and Kashmir had a separate RTI Act, repealed in 2019. Its preamble is quoted almost verbatim in questions: to provide for setting out the practical

regime of right to information for citizens to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority.

Section to subject - learn this table cold

Section	Subject
4	Suo motu or proactive disclosure by every public authority
5	Designation of Public Information Officers and Assistant PIOs
6	Request for obtaining information - no reason need be given
7	Disposal of a request - the time limits
8	Exemptions from disclosure - ten grounds
9	Rejection where disclosure would infringe the copyright of a person other than the State
10	Severability - supply the disclosable part of a record
11	Third-party information
12	Constitution of the Central Information Commission
15	Constitution of the State Information Commission
19	Appeals - first and second
20	Penalties
22	Overriding effect over the Official Secrets Act, 1923 and any inconsistent law
24	Intelligence and security organisations in the Second Schedule are exempt

- Section 6(2) - the applicant is NOT required to give any reason for the request; only contact details are needed.
- Section 8(2) - a public interest override: exempt information may still be disclosed if public interest outweighs the harm.
- Section 8(3) - information more than 20 years old is ordinarily to be supplied.
- Section 23 - bar on the jurisdiction of courts.

- Section 24 proviso - even a Second Schedule organisation must give information on allegations of CORRUPTION and HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS.
- The application fee prescribed under the RTI Rules, 2012 for a central public authority is Rs 10; applicants below the poverty line pay no fee.

ASKED IN RAS

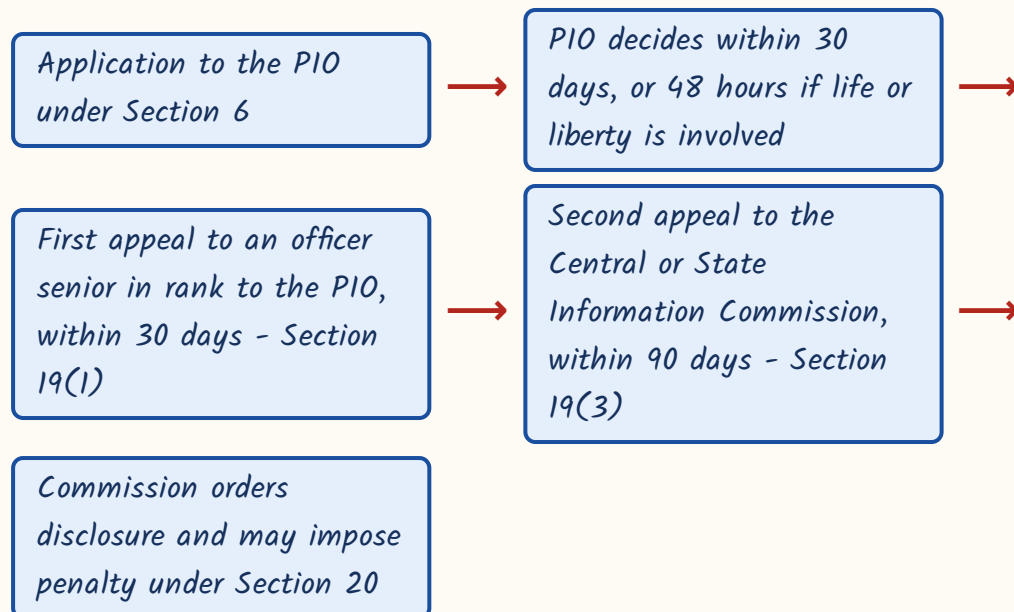
Asked in RAS Pre 2018 - the RTI Act, 2005 came fully into force with effect from? Answer: 12 October 2005. The trap version of the same fact is the statement 'Second Schedule organisations are wholly outside the Act, even for corruption' - that is false, because of the proviso to Section 24.

RTI - time limits, appeals and the penalty

This is the part RPSC has asked in three different years. There are five numbers under Section 7 and four under Sections 19 and 20. Memorise them as two strips and you have covered every numerical RTI question ever set.

- 30 days - the ordinary limit for supplying information under Section 7.
- 48 HOURS - where the information concerns the LIFE OR LIBERTY of a person.
- 35 days - where the application is filed with an Assistant Public Information Officer; the extra five days are for transmission.
- 40 days - where a third party's interest is involved.
- If the deadline is missed, the information must be supplied FREE of charge.

The RTI journey - application to second appeal



- Section 19 - first appeal within 30 days, to an officer senior in rank to the PIO.
- Section 19 - second appeal to the CIC or SIC within 90 days.
- In any appeal, the BURDEN of proving that a refusal was justified lies on the PIO, not on the citizen.
- Section 20 - penalty of Rs 250 PER DAY of delay, imposed on the Public Information Officer.
- The penalty is subject to a MAXIMUM of Rs 25,000.
- For persistent default the Commission may also recommend disciplinary action against the PIO.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - information concerning the life or liberty of a person must be provided within how long? Answer: 48 hours. Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the maximum penalty on a PIO under Section 20? Answer: Rs 25,000. Two separate papers, two separate numbers from the same Act. The number strips to say out loud: 30 - 48 hours - 35 - 40 - free, then 30 - 90 - 250 - 25,000.

The Information Commissions and the 2019 Amendment

The Central Information Commission is constituted under Section 12 and the State Information Commission under Section 15. Their structures are parallel - the same numbers, but a different appointing authority and a different committee. Learn them side by side and you will never confuse the two.

CIC vs SIC - identical shape, different people

Central Information Commission (Sec 12)	State Information Commission (Sec 15)
Chief Information Commissioner + not more than TEN Information Commissioners	State Chief Information Commissioner + up to TEN State Information Commissioners
Appointed by the PRESIDENT	Appointed by the GOVERNOR
Committee chaired by the Prime Minister	Committee chaired by the Chief Minister
Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha	Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Assembly
A Union Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister	A State Cabinet Minister nominated by the Chief Minister
First Chief Information Commissioner: Wajahat Habibullah, 2005	Rajasthan's own SIC is repeatedly asked in the Rajasthan Polity paper

Now the 2019 Amendment, which is asked in its own right. It did not touch the citizen's rights at all - it touched only the officers. It amended Sections 13, 16 and 27 so that the term of office and the salaries of the Chief Information Commissioner, the Information Commissioners and their state counterparts are no longer written into the statute; they are now 'as may be prescribed by the Central Government'. Before 2019 the Act itself fixed the term at five years and pegged the salaries of the CIC and ICs to the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners.

- Sections amended: 13, 16 and 27. Nothing else.
- The RTI Rules, 2019 fix the term at THREE years - it was five years earlier.

- The upper age limit of 65 years is unchanged.
- The Amendment did NOT remove or alter the right of second appeal to the Information Commission - Section 19 was untouched. That false statement is the standard wrong option.
- The criticism: making tenure and salary a matter of executive prescription weakens the Commissions' independence.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the Chief Information Commissioner is appointed by the President on the recommendation of a committee consisting of the PM, the LoP in the Lok Sabha, and who else? Answer: a Union Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister. RAS Pre 2021 asked the post-2019 tenure - answer: three years or until the age of 65 years.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): Raj Kumar Goyal was sworn in as Chief Information Commissioner in December 2025, and with that round of appointments the Central Information Commission was reported to have returned to its full sanctioned strength of a Chief Information Commissioner plus ten Information Commissioners. Vacancies at the CIC had been a running news story since 2023, so both the vacancy issue and the restored strength are fair current-affairs game.

The ARCs, good governance and e-governance

Two Administrative Reforms Commissions bracket this whole syllabus. Almost everything above - RTI, the Citizen's Charter, e-governance, ethics in public life - was recommended by one of them. Learn the two chairmen, the report counts,

and the four named reports of the 2nd ARC, because the report-number matching question uses exactly those four.

The two Administrative Reforms Commissions

	First ARC	Second ARC
Constituted	1966	31 August 2005
Chairman	Morarji Desai, later K. Hanumanthaiah	Veerappa Moily, later V. Ramachandran
Reports submitted	20	15
Signature recommendation	Setting up of Lokpal and Lokayuktas	Right to Information as the master key to good governance

- 2nd ARC 1st report (2006): 'Right to Information - Master Key to Good Governance'.
- 2nd ARC 4th report: 'Ethics in Governance'.
- 2nd ARC 11th report: 'Promoting e-Governance - The SMART Way Forward'.
- 2nd ARC 12th report: 'Citizen Centric Administration - The Heart of Governance'.
- The report numbers to hold are 1, 4, 11 and 12 - nothing else from the 15 is asked.
- SMART governance = Simple, Moral, Accountable, Responsive and Transparent.
- The World Bank popularised the term 'good governance' in its 1992 report 'Governance and Development'.
- The United Nations lists EIGHT attributes of good governance: participation, rule of law, transparency, responsiveness, consensus orientation, equity and inclusiveness, effectiveness and efficiency, and accountability.
- Centralisation of decision making is NOT one of them - it is the standard wrong option in the negative-framed version.

- Whistle Blowers Protection Act, 2014 - assent 9 May 2014.
- It allows public interest disclosures to the Central or State Vigilance Commission and protects the complainant's identity.
- It followed the murder of Satyendra Dubey in 2003 and the 2nd ARC's 'Ethics in Governance' report.
- It is still not fully operational - the rules have not been notified and amendments remain pending.
- Chronology for the ordering question: Freedom of Information Act 2002 - RTI Act 2005 - Whistle Blowers Protection Act 2014 - Meghalaya Social Audit Act 2017.

E-governance - initiative to year, a pure matching set

Initiative	Year or date	Detail
National e-Governance Plan	Approved 18 May 2006	27 Mission Mode Projects, later raised to 31
UIDAI set up	January 2009	Made statutory by the Aadhaar Act, 2016
First Aadhaar issued	29 September 2010	Tembhli village, Nandurbar district, Maharashtra
Direct Benefit Transfer	Launched 1 January 2013	Subsidy paid straight into the beneficiary's account
e-Kranti (NeGP 2.0)	Approved March 2015	44 Mission Mode Projects
Digital India	Launched 1 July 2015	Nine pillars and three vision areas
UMANG	2017	Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance

YAAD RAKHO

Two things to fix before the paper. The four interaction types are G2C, G2B, G2G and G2E - government to citizen, business, government and employee. And do not merge the two 2015 entries: e-Kranti was approved in MARCH 2015 with 44 MMPs, Digital India was launched on 1 JULY 2015 with nine pillars. DBT is 2013, not 2015.

REVISION RECAP

1. Thomas Dye - public policy is 'whatever governments choose to do or not to do'; Harold Lasswell is the father of the policy sciences.
2. Policy stages: agenda setting - formulation - adoption - implementation - evaluation. Implementation is executive work, never legislative.
3. Simon bounded rationality; Lindblom incrementalism or muddling through; Etzioni mixed scanning; Easton systems model; Cohen, March and Olsen the garbage can.
4. Citizen's Charter - UK 1991 under John Major; six principles are Quality, Choice, Standards, Value, Accountability, Transparency.
5. India adopted it at the Conference of Chief Ministers on 24 May 1997 under the Action Plan for Effective and Responsive Government; DARPG is the nodal agency, first charters 1997.
6. The six components: vision and mission, business transacted, clients, services to each client group, grievance redress mechanism, expectations from clients. Penalty for defaulting officials is NOT a component - asked in 2021 and 2024.
7. A charter is voluntary and non-justiciable; the standard criticism is that it is drafted without consulting citizens or staff.
8. Sevottam - three modules, Citizen's Charter, Public Grievance Redress and Service Delivery Capability, assessed against IS 15700:2005.
9. Right to services: Madhya Pradesh first (2010, effective 25 September 2010), Bihar 2011, Rajasthan Guaranteed Delivery of Public Services Act 2011, Rajasthan Right to Hearing Act 2012 - the first in India.
10. Social audit - Section 17 of MGNREGA 2005, by the Gram Sabha, at least once every six months; Audit of Scheme Rules 2011 framed with the CAG; it supplements and does not replace the CAG's audit.
11. Meghalaya Community Participation and Public Services Social Audit Act, 2017 - the first dedicated state social audit law.
12. MKSS founded 1990 at Devdungri, Rajsamand, by Aruna Roy, Nikhil Dey and Shankar Singh; slogan 'Hamara Paisa, Hamara Hisab'; Jan Sunwai grew into the national RTI campaign.
13. CPGRAMS - DARPG's portal; disposal cut from 30 to 21 days in August 2024; appeal within 30 days; the Directorate of Public Grievances sits in the Cabinet Secretariat.
14. RTI Act - assent 15 June 2005, fully in force 12 October 2005, replacing the Freedom of Information Act, 2002.
15. Sections: 4 suo motu, 5 PIOs, 6 request, 7 time limits, 8 exemptions, 9 copyright, 10 severability, 11 third party, 12 CIC, 15 SIC, 19 appeals, 20 penalty, 22 overriding effect, 24 Second Schedule.

16. Time limits: 30 days ordinary, 48 hours for life or liberty, 35 days through an Assistant PIO, 40 days with third-party interest; free if the deadline is missed.
17. Appeals: first within 30 days to an officer senior to the PIO, second within 90 days to the CIC or SIC; the burden of justifying a refusal is on the PIO.
18. Section 20 penalty: Rs 250 a day, maximum Rs 25,000, plus a recommendation of disciplinary action for persistent default.
19. CIC - President, on a committee of the PM, the LoP in Lok Sabha and a Union Cabinet Minister; SIC - Governor, on a committee of the CM, the LoP in the Assembly and a State Cabinet Minister. Each has a chief plus up to ten commissioners.
20. RTI (Amendment) Act 2019 changed only Sections 13, 16 and 27 - term and salary now prescribed by the Central Government; RTI Rules 2019 set the term at three years, age limit 65; the appeal mechanism was untouched.